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The Making of *The Quest for Dopamine*

I began this project with a fairly broad interest in mental health and games. Specifically, I wanted to see whether a game could do more than simply tell the player that a character was struggling. I was interested in the possibility that mechanics themselves could help communicate a character's internal state, especially feelings like frustration, distraction, rumination, and the gap between knowing what needs to be done and actually being able to do it. I think that interactive fiction and video games in general have a profound power to connect the player with the character they're controlling, and I wanted to evoke that feeling in a way that might seem unique or unconventional. I chose to work in Ren'Py because I found it to be the most intuitive engine we worked with this semester and it allowed me to avoid the things that frustrate me the most — namely my lack of artistic skill and having to deal with bespoke coding languages or obtuse interfaces. I also wanted to see how much expressive weight a visual novel could carry if I treated its menus, pacing, and interface as meaningful parts of the fiction rather than just containers for dialogue.

The result was *The Quest for Dopamine*, a satirical sci-fi visual novel about Kyle, a super soldier who is supposedly humanity's last hope. His mission is straightforward in the exaggerated, familiar way that many video game premises are straightforward — the President has been kidnapped, the deadline is approaching, and Kyle is the chosen hero who has to save the day. The problem is that Kyle does not feel especially invested in any of this. He is

competent, but unmotivated and disconnected from the role he has been asked to play. Instead of rushing into battle, he procrastinates, struggles to get out of bed, gets distracted on the way to the objective, and eventually detours into breakfast and a conversation with an old friend. I was drawn to that contrast between epic stakes and ordinary struggles. It felt like a neat way to explore agency not as abstract freedom or power, but as something that comes with difficulty and effort and carries different meaning for different people. As Nguyen wrote, “Just as novels let us experience lives we have not lived, games let us experience forms of agency we might not have discovered on our own. But those shaped experiences of agency can be valuable in themselves, as art” (2).

As the concept developed, I decided to lean more heavily into parody, as evidenced by the dumb opening text crawl. That choice was partly tonal and partly practical. I didn’t want the game to feel melodramatic, overly confessional, or as if it were asking the player to process someone’s personal feelings in a cringeworthy way. By exaggerating the world around Kyle, I could make his motivational struggle feel more visible without presenting it as a solemn psychological case study. At the same time, I still wanted the humor and absurdity to support a more serious design goal. My aim was not simply to joke about procrastination or mental health, but to create moments where the player would experience a small version of Kyle’s friction for themselves. In that sense, the project became an experiment in combining literary characterization with mechanical pressure. Rather than separating story from gameplay, I wanted to use the visual novel form to bring them as close together as possible.

In the conceptual phase, I referenced a few specific ways of thinking about agency, failure, and control. Jesper Juul’s point that “Players often exhibit great frustration when failing” and that “players clearly exert effort in order to avoid failure” gave me a useful way to think

about why I wanted parts of the game to feel irritating on purpose (34). I wanted players to exert effort themselves instead of simply watching it happen or reading about it. In the opening bed scene, the whole point is that getting out of bed is mechanically simple but experientially frustrating. The player knows exactly what needs to happen, but the game makes that action feel slower and harder than it should. The same logic carries into the city scene, where the menu gradually fills with distractions and the direct path forward becomes harder to parse. I liked the idea of making agency feel unstable, like it's something that the player could never truly master, without removing it entirely by making the game linear.

C. Thi Nguyen helped me understand that more clearly. His argument that “Games constitute a library of agencies, in which we may discover and familiarize ourselves with new modes of agency” made me think of the project not just as a story about Kyle, but as an attempt to let the player inhabit a fractured form of agency for a while and potentially learn from the experience (76). Instead of watching him procrastinate, they're placed inside the “system” of his brain, and this system makes their input feel less valuable and less certain. That is what made me fascinated by the mechanics instead of leaving everything in dialogue. The project is still largely scripted, but the player's limited control inside that script became one of the most important ways of expressing its ideas and themes.

The two main mechanics I finished, which are found in the bed scene and the first city scene, ended up carrying most of the game's thematic weight. In both cases, I was trying to make very ordinary kinds of difficulty feel narratively meaningful. The bed scene turns a simple action into a small cycle of effort, repetition, and likely failure. That matters because it immediately frames Kyle's struggle not as a matter of selfishness or unwillingness, but as a mismatch between intention and action. The player knows what should happen and tries to make it happen, but the

game keeps slowing that process down. The city scene takes that idea further by shifting from difficulty of initiation to difficulty of focus. As the player moves toward the mission, the interface itself becomes less trustworthy — tempting distractions multiply as the most straightforward option is gradually minimized by way of a decreasing text size and then ultimately removed. In both scenes, the systems are doing literary work by shaping the player's sense of time, effort, and narrowing control.

Afterwards, the diner scene works as a counterweight to those systems. Since the prototype's mechanics are so rough and simple, I wanted to use that section to communicate more directly through dialogue and characterization. The breakfast detour and conversation with Tanner explore Kyle's internal reality in a way the earlier choice-based scenes only imply. Instead of presenting him as a joke version of a sci-fi action hero and leaving it there, the diner scene starts to explain the emotional logic underneath the parody. It lets him talk about being good at the super-soldier role without actually feeling attached to it, and about how being good at something doesn't negate avoidance or a lack of motivation. In that sense, the scene helps subvert the genre frame from within. Also, the dialogue between the two characters is grounded and relatable in a way that recenters the absurd world building and exposition leading up to it.

Ideally, that scene would land even harder in a more fully developed version of the game. If the game had more time to sustain its tongue-in-cheek tone before arriving at breakfast, then the shift into a more personal and reflective conversation would feel more surprising and revealing. Right now that scene carries a lot of the project's literary work because the prototype is so short, but in a longer game I think it would function best as a heartwarming respite from the other scenes that would likely be some combination of funny, stressful, or bewildering. That contrast is part of what interests me. Humor goes a long way in making the audience more

vulnerable and open to connection, and this scene is intended to help Kyle transcend his goofy persona and become easier to root for.

A lot of the hardest parts of development came from the gap between the mechanics I imagined and what I could realistically execute in Ren'Py. Early on, I had ambitious ideas for more dynamic, reactive systems that would represent Kyle's struggles more creatively — such as having a choice prompt disappear over time or dart away from the player's pointer when trying to select it — but many of those ideas fizzled out once I started trying to build them. Some were simply beyond my technical ability in the time I had, while others turned out to be much harder to implement cleanly than I expected. Ren'Py is great for quickly building dialogue, menus, and simple scene structure, but once I started trying to push it toward more unusual behavior with more complex player inputs, the process became much messier. I spent a lot of time testing small mechanical ideas that either did not work at all or only worked in a rough, partial form.

The other major challenge was structural rather than conceptual. Once the game started accumulating loops, repeat choices, detours, and branching menus, keeping the script organized quickly became difficult. The city scene with the escalating distractions was the clearest example of that problem. Routing the player through multiple tempting options while making those options feel cluttered, reactive, and increasingly oppressive took a lot of trial and error. I had to keep adjusting which choices reappeared, which ones disappeared, when the scene should loop, and how to avoid repeating the same notification text too many times. Even small changes to that sequence could create new bugs or make the scene feel less intentional, which is easy to see because there are still a few loops in the finished prototype that aren't as clean as I wanted them to be. In that sense, one of the clearest lessons of the project was that even a short interactive

work can become complicated very quickly once you start extending the narrative branches and trying to balance coherence with player freedom.

In an idealized version of the game, I would extend that logic much further by making time pressure a constant presence rather than something limited to a few scenes. The version I imagine most clearly would include an overarching timer counting down to the President's execution, with different choices advancing that timer in different increments. That way, every delay or impulsive decision would carry visible consequences and create a constant undercurrent of anxiety. I think that would capture something important about executive dysfunction — it's not just the immediate frustration of getting stuck, but the awful awareness that time is passing while you are still failing to act in the way you want to. It would also strengthen the game's parody of the heroic mission structure. The player would still be in a world of absurdly high stakes and exaggerated tropes, but the actual emotional rhythm of gameplay would revolve around wasting time, feeling guilty about it, and trying to recover.

I also imagine a more mechanically and literarily layered version of the project where Kyle's internal life would have a stronger presence within the gameplay. One possibility would be internal voices that nudge either Kyle or the player in certain directions, simulating intrusive thoughts or conflicting impulses rather than leaving all of that material in dialogue. Another would be more aggressive text effects and interface distortions that make some options harder to focus on and others more tempting to select. I also like the idea of short minigames that deliver the kind of shallow dopamine hits Kyle is chasing, giving the player a brief rush of pleasure or relief while pulling them further away from the main objective. In a fuller version, I think those elements would work together to make the game feel less like a sequence of isolated scenes and

more like a sustained struggle between the mission the player is supposed to complete and all the smaller, more immediate rewards that keep getting in the way.

Overall, the process of creating *The Quest for Dopamine* further illuminated both the challenges of game development and the literary potential of the medium. Despite being unable to realize most of my vision, I enjoyed iterating from the ground level and seeing what I could accomplish in this limited development time. Unsurprisingly, the character writing and world building came the most naturally, but challenging myself by incorporating multiple branching paths, loops, and player inputs made me excited to dive deeper and explore the narrative potential of the story I envisioned. It's not as mechanically compelling or narratively cohesive as I imagined it to be, but there are definitely hints at something special that could be better realized with a lot more time and experience under my belt. Perhaps more importantly, it made me think about how games can carry literary meaning not just through writing and dialogue, but through the player's experience of structure and choice. Even in this rough form, the project helped me see more clearly how ideas about agency, failure, and interactive fiction can be explored through game design itself.

Works Cited

Jesper Juul. *The Art of Failure: An Essay on the Pain of Playing Video Games (Playful Thinking)*. Mit Press, 2013.

Nguyen, C. Thi. *Games*. Oxford University Press, 23 Apr. 2020.